
Hype Check

Nine AI tools, and whether each one actually delivers as much as people say it does. What it is, what it costs, and one thing to try in under half an hour.

1 ChatGPT Work · earns it

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ChatGPT Work

OpenAI

An agent that builds the document for you. Connect your files and apps, describe what you need, and it produces the deck or the spreadsheet rather than telling you how to make one.

WHAT IT ACTUALLY DOES

Launched July 2026. It reads from apps and files you have connected, then creates presentations, spreadsheets and other documents from that material. The difference from normal ChatGPT is that the finished artefact is the output, not a conversation about it.

PRICE

Bundled into paid ChatGPT plans

FREE TIER

No

OpenAI has not published a standalone price. Plus is around \$20/month and Pro around \$200/month. Check before assuming.

TRY THIS IN 30 MINUTES

Connect one spreadsheet you already maintain. Ask it for a ten-slide summary aimed at someone who has never seen the data. Then judge it on how much editing the draft needs, not on whether it is perfect.

SKIP IT IF

You need it to be reliable this month. It is weeks old, and how well it holds up against messy real-world files and third-party integrations has not been tested at scale yet.

Obsidian

Obsidian, independent

A genuinely excellent notes app that most people turn into a hobby. The tool is not the problem. The amount of time people spend configuring it instead of writing in it is.

WHAT IT ACTUALLY DOES

Local-first Markdown notes stored as plain files on your own machine. Notes link to each other with double brackets, a graph view shows the connections, and a large plugin ecosystem extends almost everything. Nothing is locked in a proprietary format, which is its best quality.

APP	SYNC	PUBLISH	COMMERCIAL
Free, no account needed	\$4 to \$5/month	\$8 to \$10/month per site	\$50/user/year

TRY THIS IN 30 MINUTES

Create a vault and write exactly three linked notes about one live project: the problem, who cares about it, what happens next. Install no plugins and change no themes. If it is still useful a week later, then customise it.

SKIP IT IF

You need your notes from any browser on any machine. There is no web app. Sync solves multiple devices you own, not a locked-down work laptop you cannot install software on.

NotebookLM

Google

Upload the documents you were supposed to read, then have it turn them into a summary, a slide deck, or a two-host podcast you can listen to on the way to work. The free tier is the whole product.

WHAT IT ACTUALLY DOES

You give it sources, PDFs, Docs, web pages, YouTube links, and it answers only from those. It also converts them into Audio Overviews, video overviews, infographics, slide decks and data tables. Because it is grounded in what you uploaded, it makes things up far less than a general chatbot.

Now sits under Google's Gemini branding at notebook.google.com. The NotebookLM name is still what everyone uses.

PRICE

Free with a Google account

PLUS

Included in Google AI Pro and Ultra

TRY THIS IN 30 MINUTES

Take the longest PDF sitting in your downloads folder. Upload it, ask for a summary and the three questions it does not answer, then generate the Audio Overview and listen to it on your commute.

SKIP IT IF

You want it to search the open web. It will not. It only knows what you gave it, and the audio format tends to smooth out exactly the nuance you might have needed.

Claude Design

Anthropic Labs

Describe a design in plain language and it produces slides, prototypes and marketing material. Impressive to watch. Still a research preview, which is the part people leave out.

WHAT IT ACTUALLY DOES

Released April 2026. Generates designs, prototypes, slides and marketing assets from natural language, and can pull an existing brand system out of your codebase or design files. You refine with inline comments, direct edits and sliders, then export to Canva, PDF, PPTX, HTML or hand it to Claude Code to build.

PRICE

Included with Claude Pro, Max, Team, Enterprise

FREE TIER

No

TRY THIS IN 30 MINUTES

Give it one paragraph about what you do and your brand's hex code. Ask for a five-slide pitch outline, export to PPTX, and count how many slides you keep. That number is the honest measure of it.

SKIP IT IF

You want something dependable for client work. Research preview means it can change or disappear, and it is not available at all without a paid Claude plan.

Codex

OpenAI

Hand it a task, it goes away, works in its own sandboxed copy of your code, and comes back with a pull request and the test results. Over two million people a week use it while the internet argues about models.

WHAT IT ACTUALLY DOES

An autonomous coding agent. It writes features, fixes bugs, answers questions about a codebase, runs tests and proposes changes, working in isolated cloud environments preloaded with your repository. Jobs typically take between one and thirty minutes and return logs you can actually read.

Not the 2021 Codex that autocompleted code and was retired in 2023. Different product, same name. As of July 2026 the desktop app is folded into the ChatGPT app.

CLI

Free and open source

CLOUD

Included in paid ChatGPT plans

TRY THIS IN 30 MINUTES

Point the CLI at a folder of your own scripts and ask it to document every function and write a README. Read the diff before you accept it. Reviewing its work is the skill worth building.

SKIP IT IF

You do not already work with repositories and pull requests. The whole workflow assumes that vocabulary, and without it the output is hard to judge.

Hermes Agent

Nous Research

An agent that lives in your messaging apps and remembers you between conversations. Loud claims, and it mostly backs them up, but you have to be willing to run it yourself.

WHAT IT ACTUALLY DOES

Open source under MIT. Connects to more than twenty messaging platforms including Telegram, Slack, Discord, WhatsApp and Signal, and runs on your machine, a server, or Docker. Its distinguishing feature is a learning loop: it writes its own reusable skills from experience and builds a picture of how you work across sessions. It can drive Claude, GPT, Gemini and hundreds of other models.

Different thing from the Hermes family of open-weight models by the same team, which is a common mix-up.

AGENT

Free, MIT licensed

MODELS

Your own API keys, or the Nous Portal

Nous Portal subscription pricing is not published.

TRY THIS IN 30 MINUTES

Install it, add one API key, connect Telegram, and ask for a daily 9am briefing on one topic you actually track. If it still shows up on day three, it has earned a place.

SKIP IT IF

A terminal makes you nervous. Setup means the command line, API keys and model configuration. Worth knowing too that a self-improving agent is deciding what to remember about you.

OpenClaw

OpenClaw Foundation

One of the fastest-growing open source projects there has ever been. Starring it takes a second. Keeping it running is the part nobody posts about.

WHAT IT ACTUALLY DOES

A self-hosted gateway that puts one AI assistant into all your chat apps at once, WhatsApp, Telegram, Slack, iMessage, Discord, Teams, Signal and more, with shared memory across them. You run a single gateway process on your own machine or a server. There are companion apps for every major platform and a plugin marketplace called ClawHub.

PRICE

Free, self-hosted

REAL COST

Your model API usage, plus your time

TRY THIS IN 30 MINUTES

Run the onboarding, connect one channel only, and give it a single real task such as summarising five recent papers on a topic you follow. One channel that works beats eight half-configured ones.

SKIP IT IF

You do not want to be the systems administrator. Self-hosted means you own setup, security, updates and outages. Around twenty channel plugins and several backend options is a lot of surface area for something that is meant to save you time.

OpenCode

Anomaly Co.

A coding agent that does not care which model you use. More than seventy-five providers, swap whenever you like, and a read-only mode so you can point it at something important without holding your breath.

WHAT IT ACTUALLY DOES

Free and MIT licensed, available as a terminal app, a desktop app or an IDE extension. Two modes matter: Plan reads your code and explains it without touching anything, Build makes the changes. Because it is model agnostic, you are never stuck when one provider raises prices or a better model arrives.

Repository moved from `sst/opencode` to `anomalyco/opencode` when the team spun it out.

PRICE

Free, MIT licensed

MODELS

Your own keys, or optional Zen credits

TRY THIS IN 30 MINUTES

Install it, open a codebase you inherited and do not understand, and run it in Plan mode. Ask what the project does and where it starts. It cannot change anything in that mode, so there is nothing to be careful about.

SKIP IT IF

You want a graphical tool. The terminal interface is the main experience, and bringing your own model means handling API keys yourself.

Claude Code

Anthropic

Loudly talked about, and it holds up. This is the one the others get compared to, which is why it sits level rather than underrated. The noise is large and so is the thing.

WHAT IT ACTUALLY DOES

An agent that works from your terminal in plain English. It reads your files, writes code, runs commands and asks permission before it changes anything. Released February 2025, generally available that May, with a web version since October 2025. Its real significance is how many non-programmers now use it to build small tools that used to require hiring someone.

TOOL

Free to install

USAGE

Needs a Claude subscription or API access

Pro is widely reported around \$20/month, with Max tiers above it. Confirm current pricing directly.

TRY THIS IN 30 MINUTES

Make an empty folder, run it, and describe something small and real: take a CSV of expenses, total it by category, print a summary. Do not write any code. The point is to find out where the line is now.

SKIP IT IF

Cost surprises bother you. Complex tasks consume tokens quickly. It also needs broad access to your files and terminal, which is worth thinking about before you hand it a work machine.